Strauss was popularly assumed to be playing for his Test career in New Zealand. Distracted and struggling to sleep, he reached his lowest point in the first innings at Napier, when he batted at three and was caught in the gully, off debutant Tim Southee, for 0.

He had dinner that evening with his wife Ruth and told her he was playing his last Test match. Ironically, in a delicate situation where offering advice to a teammate can feel intrusive, Colly provided unlikely impetus by telling him to concentrate on his natural game, the pull and cut shots. Straussy scored 177, set up a 121-run win and was England captain within a year.

What did I have to lose? I reached the conclusion I would rather play a massive drive and nick off, than briefly delay an inevitable dismissal by defending obsessively. It was a good pitch, and I had been fortunate to survive an edge through the slips the previous evening. I resolved not to make what had become a familiar mistake, in failing to get forward, and being trapped on the crease. I hit the first ball of the day, outside off stump, through midwicket for four. The shackles were off.

My footwork was sharper, my form more fluent. Though I edged a couple, I was 76 not out at lunch, and dominating what would be a partnership of 116 with Jonathan Trott. In an eerie foretaste of what was to come nine years later, I reached my century in bizarre fashion, when Mohammad Asif, the bowler, returned the ball over my head for four overthrows.

That 110 was enough to secure my place on the subsequent Ashes tour, where Bawds gave me a book called *The Confidence Gap* by Russ Harris, an exiled English psychologist and life coach whose CV includes stints as a stand-up comedian, sex therapist, filmmaker and novelist. It used the concept of Acceptance and Commitment Therapy to introduce me to the Gimp, who had so often been sitting malevolently on my shoulder.

I have a natural aversion to motivational mumbo-jumbo but this was a little different. I didn’t read more than twenty pages but it was enough to set me thinking. I realized self-doubt was a common thread, linking someone as externally resolute as me to a supposedly supreme example of self-confidence such as President Obama. Human beings are apparently hard wired to think negatively; it is a basic survival instinct.

How, and why, could that be related to cricket? I mulled it over for a couple of days. Then it was off to a pub in Adelaide, to complete a